

approximately 1,000 times the typical “background” rate in evolutionary history, and we are dramatically reducing the population size of many other species, putting them at existential risk. Scholars call this the “Sixth Mass Extinction.” We are overfarming the soils and transforming arable land into desert. We are clearing tropical rain forests for livestock grazing, primarily to feed wealthier consumers, because they find beef tasty. We are ruining the oceans, polluting them with plastics while depleting the stocks of fish. Our good friends, the South African penguins, are facing extinction, thanks to human economic expansion.

We need to take a look in the mirror and ask ourselves, are we going to be smart, or are we going to be stupid? What kinds of changes are needed to avert a permanent catastrophe? Can we build a global society that respects Mother Nature, and that is also fair and just? And what does any of this have to do with digital technology? This book addresses these questions.

DIGITAL DEGROWTH

If we’re going to be smart, then we need to understand what is causing this unfolding disaster—before it’s too late. That requires us to take a deep look at human society. As we’ll see throughout this book, digital technology is central to the state of the environment. It not only alters how we conduct our day-to-day lives, it also drives the global economy. The digital economy is not only overheating the planet and destroying biodiversity, it increases inequality within and between countries, stimulates consumerism, enhances surveillance and technologies of violence, boosts the power of militaries, and strengthens propaganda. All of this undermines the environment.

Before we launch into the digital connection, let’s start with the basics. The global economy is organized through *capitalism*, a system that is predicated on *limitless growth* that is destroying the planet. As we will see, the solution to this is *degrowth*—the re-engineering of society to produce a good life for everyone within planetary boundaries.

Capitalists arrange economic activity by investing resources into enterprises that grow. The more growth, the more wealth and return on investment. Capitalism also produces high degrees of inequality. Those in favor of capitalism argue that inequality can be justified because total growth makes everyone wealthier, even if some people are richer than others.